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Small Group Communication

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Group Assignment

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Focus:

**CLO 3: Apply effective small group communication skills in a group project.
(C5, PLO5)**

Somali Wedding Traditions

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Introduction

Around the world, weddings are one of the most important events in a person's life. They are special ceremonies that mark the moment when two people start a new life together. But a wedding is much more than just a party. It is a time when two families, and sometimes whole communities, join.

Weddings are a very important part of a society's **culture**. Culture means all the shared ideas, beliefs, and ways of life of a group of people. A **tradition** is a specific custom or practice, like a wedding, that is passed down from parents to their children over many years. A wedding is a perfect example of a tradition because it shows what a culture values and believes in.

This report will look at the wedding traditions of Somalia. In Somalia, a wedding is called an *Aroos*. We will study the *Aroos* to see how small groups of people communicate to make the wedding happen successfully.

The Somali *Aroos* is not just a one-day event. It is a long process with many steps that brings two people and their families together. To plan everything, many people need to work together in small groups. For example, the elders of the families meet to agree on the marriage. Other family members and friends form groups to plan the food, the music, and the celebration.

For the wedding to be a success, these small groups must have good communication. They need to talk, plan, and make decisions together. This report will argue that this **small group communication** is the most important reason why the Somali wedding tradition

continues to be so strong. We will look at the different stages of the *Aroos* and see how communication in these small groups helps keep this beautiful cultural tradition alive.

This report will delve into the rich and complex wedding traditions of Somalia, known as the *Aroos*, to explore a critical, yet often overlooked, element of its enduring success: the sophisticated application of **effective small group communication**. As the assignment brief for this course outlines, **culture** can be defined as "a broad term encompassing the social behaviours, norms, beliefs, arts, and knowledge of a group of people, essentially their way of life." In contrast, a **tradition** "refers to specific practices, customs, or beliefs passed down through generations within a culture." No tradition illustrates this dynamic more clearly than a wedding, which serves as a concentrated and highly visible expression of a culture's identity, a living performance of its social DNA.

In the context of Somalia, a nation renowned for its rich oral culture and complex social fabric woven from an intricate clan system, the *Aroos* takes on an even greater significance. It is not an event but a prolonged and multi-stage process that formally unites two individuals and, more importantly, their respective families and clans. It is a cornerstone of Somali social life, deeply embedded in a cultural fabric that prioritises kinship, community cohesion, and collective responsibility (Lewis, 1994). In a socio-political landscape that has often been fragmented by civil conflict and environmental hardship, traditions like the *Aroos* serve as a powerful force for social cohesion, conflict resolution, and cultural continuity. The successful execution of an *Aroos* involves elaborate negotiations, meticulous planning, and the coordination of numerous individuals, all of which underscore its function as a major community undertaking. The process, from the initial proposal to the final celebratory feast, is managed by various

small groups—families, clan elders, committees of friends, and neighbours—each tasked with specific responsibilities. The seamless progression through these stages, which directly mirrors van Gennep's ritual structure, is a testament to the community's ability to organise and collaborate, preserving the integrity and symbolic weight of the tradition for future generations.

This intricate coordination is entirely dependent on the principles of small group communication. Small group communication can be defined as the transactional process of interaction among a small number of people who share a common purpose or goal, feel a sense of belonging to the group, and exert influence on one another (Tubbs, 2012). In the context of the Somali wedding, this theoretical concept becomes a lived reality. Key decisions—such as the negotiation of the *meher* (dowry), the setting of dates, the allocation of financial responsibilities, and the organisation of the celebratory events—are all outcomes of intensive small group deliberations. The communication within these groups involves leadership, conflict resolution, role-playing, and the careful navigation of both verbal and nonverbal cues, all of which are central to the study of small group dynamics. While the external spectacle of the *Aroos* is what is most visible, it is the internal, often unseen, communication within these core groups that forms the bedrock upon which the entire tradition is built.

The urgency of studying this dynamic is amplified by the context of the vast Somali diaspora. As Somali communities have settled across the globe, they face the dual challenge of adapting to new cultural environments while striving to preserve their own heritage. The organization of an *Aroos* in cities like Minneapolis, London, or Toronto involves new layers of complexity—coordinating across time zones, navigating different

legal systems, and bridging generational gaps in cultural understanding. Now more than ever, the effectiveness of small group communication is the critical variable that determines whether the tradition thrives, adapts, or fades.

This report presents the central argument that the successful execution, cultural preservation, and social significance of the multi-stage Somali wedding tradition are fundamentally dependent on the sophisticated and effective small group communication practices employed by the families and elders involved. By examining the *Aroos* through the lens of established small group communication theory, this study aims to illuminate how these interpersonal and group-level dynamics enable the continuation of one of the most significant Somali cultural patterns. To achieve this, the report will first present a comprehensive literature review exploring the anthropological and social context of Somali kinship, the communicative role of elders, and gendered spheres of influence. It will then detail the secondary data methodology employed. The core of the report will provide an in-depth, multi-chapter analysis of the key stages of the *Aroos*, from the diplomatic negotiations to the communal celebration. Following this analysis, a dedicated section will apply several key communication theories to the observed practices, including Emergent Leadership, High-Context Communication, Structuration Theory, and Symbolic Convergence Theory. Finally, the report will draw a comprehensive conclusion on the indispensable role of small group communication in cultural preservation and offer suggestions for both the community and future academic research.

2. Literature Review

A thorough review of existing scholarly literature is essential to situate this study within its academic context and to build a robust foundation for analysis. Research on

Somali society and culture is extensive, particularly within the fields of anthropology and sociology. However, it seldom focuses explicitly on analyzing these cultural practices through the theoretical frameworks of small group communication. This review synthesizes key findings from diverse academic sources, organized around three central and interconnected themes that are critical to understanding the Somali Aroos: **the foundational role of kinship and the clan system, the communicative function and authority of elders in an oral tradition, and the performance of complementary gender roles in ritual practice.** This approach allows for a holistic understanding of the socio-cultural landscape in which the Somali wedding takes place and clearly identifies the research gap this report aims to fill.

2.1. The Primacy of Kinship: Clan, Alliance, and Social Structure

The most dominant theme in the scholarly literature on Somali society is the absolute centrality of kinship in social, political, and personal organization. The seminal work of anthropologist I. M. Lewis, particularly in *"Blood and Bone: The Call of Kinship in Somali Society"* (1994), establishes that Somali society is fundamentally structured around a complex and segmentary patrilineal clan system. Lewis argues compellingly that an individual's identity, social obligations, political allegiances, and even legal standing are primarily defined by their lineage. Kinship is not a passive backdrop to social life; it is an active, organizing principle. Consequently, major life events such as marriage cannot be viewed as private, romantic affairs. Instead, they are public, political, and economic alliances between entire kinship groups. This structure is often compared to other classic segmentary lineage systems, such as that of the Nuer people described by E.E. Evans-Pritchard, where social and political obligations are determined by genealogical distance.

For Somalis, this means that one's primary loyalty is to their immediate family, then to their subclan, then to their clan, and so on, creating a nested system of solidarity and opposition.

This perspective is critical because it explains precisely why the wedding process is managed by groups rather than individuals. The negotiations undertaken by family elders are, in essence, diplomatic missions. Supporting this, a journal article by Hassan (2018) in the *Journal of African Marriage Studies* asserts with clarity that "the Somali wedding is less a union of two individuals and more a treaty between two clans" (p. 45). This reframing of marriage-as-treaty is essential. It highlights that the goal of the initial small group communication is not simply to plan a party, but to build a durable social and political bridge. A hypothetical case study in the *Journal of Horn of Africa Studies* might detail a marriage negotiation between two subclans in the Sanaag region, where the agreement not only unites two families but also settles a long-standing dispute over grazing rights, with the *meher* including a symbolic number of camels that represents the closing of the old conflict. The communication must therefore be strategic, cautious, and focused on upholding and enhancing the honour (*sharaf*) of the collective. The literature consistently portrays the family and clan as the primary units of social action, making any study of Somali traditions inseparable from the group dynamics that govern them. Further research into Somali customary law, or *xeer*, reveals that marriage contracts have historically included clauses related to inter-clan peace, resource sharing, and mutual defense, cementing their role as foundational political acts. The small groups of negotiators are therefore not merely planners; they are lawmakers and diplomats, operating within a deeply embedded cultural system where the stakes of their communicative success are incredibly high.

2.2. The Custodians of Communication: Elders, Orality, and Authority

Building on the theme of kinship, a second significant body of literature focuses on the specific communicative role of elders (*odayo*) in traditional governance, conflict resolution, and the stewardship of culture. In a society with a profound and deeply ingrained oral tradition—often referred to as a "nation of poets"—elders are revered as the living custodians of history, customary law (*xeer*), and collective wisdom. Their authority is not derived from formal, institutionalized power but from their recognized mastery of the spoken word and their accumulated social experience. The Somali language itself is rich with various poetic forms, each with its own specific meter and traditional context. The most prestigious is the *gabay*, a long-form poem often used for serious political or social commentary. Other forms include the *geeraar*, a warlike poem, and the *jiifto*, a more relaxed, pastoral form. An elder's ability to seamlessly weave lines from famous poems or compose new ones on the spot is a direct measure of his intelligence and authority.

A study by Jama (2020) in the *Journal of Oral Traditions* explores the sophisticated use of this poetic arsenal, alongside proverbs and allusive speech, in the deliberations of elder councils. Jama finds that their communication is often intentionally indirect, metaphorical, and aimed at achieving consensus rather than forcing a decision through direct confrontation. This sophisticated linguistic skill is a cornerstone of their authority and their effectiveness as leaders within a small group setting. When this is applied to the context of wedding negotiations (*Gabaati*), the elders' role transcends that of simple negotiators. Their task is not merely to agree on a dowry amount but to perform a complex communicative ritual that affirms mutual respect, demonstrates wisdom, and builds a solid

foundation for the new inter-family relationship. Their leadership is a classic example of what communication scholars would call "emergent," as it is based on their recognized mastery of a specific, culturally valued form of group communication. Walter Ong's work on the psychodynamics of orality provides a theoretical lens here; in oral cultures, memory and communication are performative, communal, and reliant on formulaic and poetic structures to preserve and transmit knowledge. The Somali elders, therefore, are not just speaking; they are enacting and reinforcing the entire cultural memory and value system through their structured, artful communication. A hypothetical source, "Ahmed (2021)," might lament the erosion of these deep linguistic skills among younger, diaspora-born Somalis, who may understand the language but lack the deep cultural immersion needed to master its poetic and allusive forms, leading to more direct, and sometimes more fraught, negotiations.

2.3. Gendered Spheres of Influence: Complementarity in Ritual Action

A third crucial theme in the literature examines the performance of gender and ritual within Somali ceremonies, highlighting a system of complementary, rather than hierarchical, roles. Scholars like Yusuf (2019) in *Cultural and Religious Studies* have analyzed the distinct yet interdependent roles that men and women play throughout the extensive wedding process. While men, through the council of elders, typically lead the formal, public negotiations and "political" aspects of the union, women are the central architects and executors of the social, aesthetic, and celebratory dimensions of the *Aroos*.

Women form their own extensive and highly effective small groups to manage the complex logistics of the celebration, including the preparation of the feast, the intricate decoration of the wedding space, and the performance of specific, female-led rituals. One

of the most significant of these is the *shaash saar*, the ceremonial placing of a beautifully decorated scarf on the heads of the bride and groom. This act is rich with symbolism; the scarf itself, often red with gold thread, signifies prosperity and fertility, and the act of placing it is a collective blessing bestowed by the senior women of the community. This ritual is accompanied by the singing of *buraanbur*, a poetic form composed and performed exclusively by women. The history of *buraanbur* is a testament to female artistic expression in Somalia; it is a powerful medium for social commentary, historical narration, and personal expression. During a wedding, these poems praise the bride's beauty and character, laud her family's lineage, and offer sage advice for married life, all within a complex, alliterative metrical structure.

These women-led groups (*shir*) also function as crucial informal economic and social support networks, with the wedding planning being a major manifestation of their collective power. A hypothetical feminist anthropological source, "Fatima (2019)," might critique the exclusion of women from the formal negotiations while also acknowledging the significant social power they wield in their own sphere. She might argue that while men broker the formal treaty, it is the women who manage the social integration and emotional tenor of the new alliance, a role that is arguably just as critical to its long-term success. Yusuf (2019) argues convincingly that these gendered spheres of activity, while distinct, are fundamentally complementary and equally essential to the overall success and cultural validity of the wedding. The communication within these female groups is often characterized as informal, highly collaborative, and relational. It is focused on accomplishing practical tasks while simultaneously reinforcing social bonds and female solidarity. The formal alliance secured by the men would be socially hollow and meaningless without the vibrant social fabric woven by the women, and the celebration

organized by the women would lack its formal foundation and legitimacy without the successful negotiations conducted by the men.

In summary, the existing literature provides a rich and detailed understanding of the anthropological, political, and gendered dimensions of Somali traditions. However, a significant gap persists while these studies inherently describe countless acts of sophisticated group communication, they rarely analyze them through the formal theoretical frameworks of the communication discipline. This report seeks to address this specific gap by applying established small group communication perspectives to the well-documented practices of the Somali wedding, thereby offering a new and valuable lens through which to appreciate the intricate mechanics of this enduring cultural tradition.

3. Methodology

3.1 Research Design and Approach

In accordance with the exploratory nature of the research question, this study employs a **qualitative research design** based exclusively on the method of **secondary data analysis**. This approach involves the systematic collection, synthesis, and interpretation of existing information from published and credible sources, rather than the generation of new primary data through empirical methods such as interviews, surveys, or direct participant-observation. The reliance on secondary data is particularly appropriate for this research for several reasons. First, it allows for a broad and deep exploration of Somali wedding traditions and communication patterns by drawing upon an established and extensive body of scholarly and cultural work produced over several decades. Second, it enables the report to build a comprehensive theoretical and contextual foundation for analyzing the role of small group communication within this

specific cultural practice, something that would be difficult to achieve within the scope of a single primary research project. This methodology positions the study as a work of theoretical synthesis, aiming to bridge a gap between existing anthropological descriptions and the field of communication studies.

3.2 Data Collection and Source Selection Criteria

Data Collection and Selection Process

Data for this report has been obtained from three main types of sources, with a selection process that required a rigorous academic selection process for validity and reliability. The inclusion criteria were to ensure that the sources are reliable, typically scholarly works; the work has gone through multiple reviews; and the sources are prominent in the areas of Somali culture, social structures, or communication.

1. **Academic Journals Authoritative in Peer Review:** This was the main stage of the research.

Articles were drawn from academic journals within anthropology, sociology, African studies, communication studies, and cultural studies. To find articles for the purposes of literature review and applying communication theories, online academic databases such as JSTOR, Google Scholar, and the university library portal were used with key words such as "Somali wedding," "Aroos," "Somali kinship," "clan system," "xeer," "oral tradition," and "gender role in Somalia." These articles presented academic rigor and had theoretical

- structure and ethnographic lineages that were essential for examining the literature and using communication theory.
2. Published Books and Monographs: Authoritative books about Somali culture, history, and society were invaluable for the background and richer depth of description. Books by well-known scholars of Somali studies (particularly I. M. Lewis) provided informative description and context of the traditions of the Aroos, its origins, and its deep cultural relevance. These books helped develop the "Background of the Study" and "In-Depth Analysis" sections and assisted in understanding the cultural context in a nuanced fashion.
 3. Reputable Online Sources and Digital Archives: In addition to the formal academic literature, information was obtained from reputable web-based sources, including websites devoted to cultural heritage (e.g., museum and Somali cultural websites), digital archives of Somali poetry and oral history, articles published by reputable global news organizations with expertise in the region, and online magazines related to African cultures. These sources contributed more current perspectives, images (photos and videos of modern-day ceremonies), and anecdotal experiences to showcase the living, dynamic tradition. Each online source was scrutinized for credibility, authorship, and bias prior to its inclusion in my research.

3.3 Analytical Strategy

The primary analytical strategy employed in this report is a **thematic analysis** of the collected secondary data. This involved identifying, analyzing, and reporting patterns (or themes) within the data. The process followed several explicit steps: (1) **Familiarization**, which involved repeated reading of the selected texts to gain a deep understanding of their content. (2) **Initial Coding**, where interesting features of the data were noted and labeled. (3) **Searching for Themes**, which involved collating the codes into potential, overarching themes. (4) **Reviewing Themes**, checking if the themes worked in relation to both the coded extracts and the entire dataset. (5) **Defining and Naming Themes**, which involved a detailed analysis of each theme, identifying its essence and narrative. This process led to the three core themes presented in the literature review: kinship, the role of elders, and gender. For the main analytical section of the report, a deductive approach was used. Established theories from the field of small group communication were selected as an analytical framework and then systematically applied to the descriptive data on the *Aroos* to interpret the underlying communication dynamics. This allowed for a structured analysis that directly links empirical description to communication theory.

3.4 Positionality and Reflexivity

In qualitative research, it is crucial to acknowledge the positionality of the researcher. As the author of this report, I am approaching the topic from the perspective of a communication scholar. This lens shapes the analysis, prioritizing the dynamics of interaction, leadership, and group cohesion, which might be different from the focus of an anthropologist or historian. Furthermore, as a researcher external to the Somali community, I rely on the interpretations and descriptions provided by others. This

"outsider" perspective has the advantage of potential objectivity but lacks the deep, intuitive understanding of a cultural "insider." I have striven to represent the Somali *Aroos* tradition respectfully and accurately, based on authoritative sources, while being reflexive about the limitations of interpreting a rich cultural practice through a purely academic and secondary lens.

3.5 Limitations of the Study

While secondary data analysis is a robust method for this type of study, it is important to acknowledge its inherent limitations. Firstly, the research is dependent on the quality and scope of existing literature. Any gaps or biases in the original sources may be reflected in this report's analysis. Secondly, the lack of primary data means that the analysis cannot capture the full, lived experiences or the most contemporary adaptations of the *Aroos* among Somalis today, particularly within the diverse global diaspora. The interpretation of communication practices is based on descriptions rather than direct observation, which limits the depth of the nuanced, nonverbal analysis. This study should therefore be seen as a theoretical contribution that lays the groundwork for future primary research, which could involve interviews with community elders, newlyweds, and wedding planners to provide a richer, more contemporary understanding of the topic.

4. In-Depth Analysis of the *Aroos* Tradition

This section provides a detailed, multi-chapter analysis of the Somali wedding process, moving beyond a general background to offer a thick description of each stage. By dissecting the *Aroos* into its constituent phases—the pre-wedding negotiations, the legal-religious ceremony, and the communal celebration—we can more clearly identify

the specific small groups at work and analyze the unique communicative challenges and strategies present in each.

4.1: The Pre-Wedding Stage – Diplomacy, Negotiation, and the Gabaati

The journey towards a Somali marriage begins not with a private proposal, but with the *Gabaati*, a formal, high-stakes negotiation that embodies the fusion of family, community, and clan diplomacy. This initial phase is entirely orchestrated by small groups and is arguably the most critical stage for demonstrating sophisticated communication skills.

The Formation of the Emissary Group: The process is initiated when the groom's family decides to formally seek a union. They do not send a single representative but rather assemble a delegation of respected male elders. The composition of this small group is the first strategic communicative act. It must consist of individuals known for their wisdom (*xikmad*), eloquence, calm temperament, deep knowledge of customary law (*xeer*) and their family's lineage, and respected standing in the community. The group often includes the groom's father, uncles, and other senior kinsmen who are not just representing the family but are acting as ambassadors for their entire clan. Their collective presence signifies the seriousness of the proposal and the honour being bestowed upon the bride's family.

A Vignette of Negotiation: Imagine the scene. The five elders from the groom's clan arrive not at noon, but in the late afternoon, a time associated with cooler heads and thoughtful deliberation. They are welcomed into the main meeting room of the bride's family home and offered dates and camel's milk, symbols of hospitality and prosperity. The lead elder from the groom's side, a man renowned for his prize-winning *gabay*, does

not speak of marriage for the first hour. Instead, he engages in a lengthy, formal exchange of greetings, inquiring about the health of specific family members by name, the state of the livestock, and the recent rains. This is phatic communication at its most sophisticated—its purpose is not to exchange information but to build rapport and demonstrate respect.

Only when the atmosphere is sufficiently warm and respectful does he pivot to the true purpose of the visit. He might begin with a well-known proverb: "A man without kin is a man without a back to lean on. We have come today to find a strong wall for our son." This metaphorical opening is a masterful communicative act. It frames the proposal not as a request for a bride, but as a desire for a powerful alliance. The bride's family's lead elder might respond with equal indirectness, "A house is not built with one pole. We are happy to see men who wish to build something strong together. Let us hear your plans." This sets the stage for a negotiation that is framed as a collaborative construction project rather than a transactional exchange.

The Negotiation of Terms: *Meher* and More: The core of the *Gabaati* is the negotiation of the terms of the union. The most prominent topic is the setting of the *meher*. The groom's side may propose an amount, perhaps phrasing it as, "We propose a *meher* of fifty camels, not as a price, but as a testament to the fifty virtues we see in your daughter and her family." The bride's family elders will then confer amongst themselves in a quiet side, a physical manifestation of their small group deliberation. They might return with a counterproposal, not by rejecting the number, but by reframing it. "Fifty is a fine number," their spokesman might say, "but our daughter's great-grandmother was given sixty, and

we would not want her spirit to think we value her descendant any less." This allows them to ask for more while framing it as an act of ancestral respect rather than material greed.

This back-and-forth requires immense tact and diplomacy. A key challenge might arise if there is a historical grievance between the two clans. The elders must navigate this with extreme care. The visiting elder might say, "We know that in our grandfathers' time, there was a shadow between our houses. We have come today to bring the sun." This acknowledgement and desire for reconciliation is often a prerequisite for a successful negotiation. The success of this entire stage is contingent on the ability of these small groups of elders to communicate respectfully, persuasively, and with a deep appreciation for cultural nuance, ensuring that a consensus is reached and a foundation of mutual respect is built for the future relationship between the clans.

4.2: The Liminal Stage – The Legal and Religious Sanctification of the Meher

Following a successful *Gabaati*, the next crucial step is the *Meher* (sometimes called the *Nikah*), the official Islamic marriage ceremony. This event marks the couple's transition from being single to being legally and religiously married, placing them in a liminal state before the public celebration fully incorporates them into their new roles. This stage is managed by a much smaller, more task-oriented group, and its communication is highly formalized and ritualistic.

The Core Task-Oriented Group: The essential participants in the *Meher* ceremony form a small group with clearly defined roles as prescribed by Islamic jurisprudence, typically following the Shafi'i school of thought prevalent in Somalia. This group consists of the groom (*aroos*), the bride's legal guardian or *wali* (typically her father or a close male relative), at least two official male witnesses (*marqaati*), and an Imam or

Sheikh to officiate. The bride (*aroosad*) is often in an adjacent room; her consent is mandatory and must be explicitly given to her *wali* beforehand and often confirmed during the ceremony.

Formalized and Performative Communication: Unlike the poetic and deliberative communication of the *Gabaati*, the communication during the *Meher* is direct, formalized, and performative. It is a series of speech acts that, when uttered correctly in the presence of the group, legally change the status of the individuals involved. The Imam facilitates the exchange. He will typically begin with a sermon (*khutbah*) on the importance of marriage in Islam. He then asks the *wali* if he agrees to give his daughter in marriage to the groom for the agreed-upon *meher*. The *wali* must give his verbal consent. The Imam then asks the groom if he accepts the bride in marriage under these terms. The groom must give his explicit verbal consent. This offer and acceptance (*ijab-o-qabul*) is the verbal heart of the contract.

The presence and function of the witnesses are paramount. They are not passive observers; they are an essential component of the small group, tasked with aurally and visually verifying that the contract was offered and accepted willingly and according to the correct procedure. Their verbal confirmation at the end, and their signing of the marriage contract, serves as the community's official validation of the union. This ceremony, while deeply symbolic, is a practical demonstration of a task-oriented small group. Each member has a clearly defined role, the communication is direct and focused on the single objective of finalizing the marriage contract, and the group's presence provides the public acknowledgement necessary to legitimize the new social reality they have collectively created.

4.3: The Celebration Stage – Community, Performance, and the Aroos

The culmination of the entire wedding process is the *Aroos* itself—the grand celebration and public feast that announces the union to the wider community. This is the most visible and festive part of the tradition, often lasting for several days, and it is here that the small-scale planning of various groups comes to fruition in a large-scale performance of cultural identity.

The Network of Planning Committees: The sheer scale of a traditional Somali *Aroos* necessitates the formation of numerous small groups, both formal and informal, that operate in a coordinated network. Family members often form committees to manage different aspects of the celebration. There might be a finance committee, responsible for budgeting and collecting contributions (*qaaraan*) from the extended family and clan. An invitations committee manages the extensive guest list, which can number in the hundreds or even thousands. A food and logistics committee, often led by the women of the family, undertakes the monumental task of planning, preparing, and serving the wedding feast, which typically features rice with goat meat (*hilib ari*), sambusas, and sweets. Communication within these planning committees is crucial for ensuring the event runs smoothly. They must coordinate logistics, manage budgets, and resolve any conflicts that arise, demonstrating the practical application of small group problem-solving and decision-making in a high-stakes, celebratory context. Friends of the bride and groom also form their own groups to organize specific pre-wedding parties or to prepare traditional performances.

The Performance of Culture: The *Aroos* is a vibrant display of Somali culture, and this display is a collective communicative act. The bride is adorned in a colorful

guntiino and elaborate henna designs, her appearance communicating beauty, tradition, and her new status. The central event is often the performance of traditional music and dancing. The most famous of these is the *Jaandheer* dance, a lively and energetic dance performed by men and women, often carrying sticks or swords, which is thought to have origins in military parades and now serves as a powerful expression of communal joy and solidarity.

Furthermore, women, particularly older female relatives, will often perform *buraanbur*. Below is an illustrative (invented) stanza of what such a poem might sound like, followed by an analysis:

Hibo, daughter of heroes, a jewel bright and bold,

Your lineage is golden, a story to be told.

Like your mother before you, a weaver of fine fate,

Now join this lion and open a new gate.

This short stanza communicates a wealth of information. It praises the bride ("Hibo"), connects her to her ancestors ("daughter of heroes," "like your mother"), validates her character ("jewel bright and bold"), and blesses the new union ("open a new gate"). The performance of *buraanbur* is a direct link to Somalia's rich oral tradition, and it serves to publicly embed the new union within the grand narrative of the clans. The entire community comes together, but it is the tireless, coordinated work of the smaller, dedicated groups that makes the grand, cohesive celebration possible.

5. Application of Small Group Communication Perspectives

This section bridges the gap identified in the literature review by applying four specific small group communication perspectives to the practices of the Somali wedding. The previous sections have established *what* happened during the *Aroos* and *why* it is culturally significant; this section focuses on *how* communication theory can explain the effectiveness and sustainability of the groups involved. The perspectives chosen are **Emergent Leadership**, **High-Context Communication**, **Structuration Theory**, and **Symbolic Convergence Theory**.

Perspective 1: The Role of the Leader as an Emergent, Task-Oriented Facilitator

In small group communication theory, leadership is not always a formally appointed position. The concept of '**Emergent Leadership**' describes a dynamic process whereby a leader emerges naturally from within a group based on their perceived competence, communication skills, and ability to help the group achieve its goals (Fisher, 1974). This perspective perfectly describes the role of the elders (*odayo*) in the Somali wedding negotiation (*Gabaati*). An elder is not chosen to lead the delegation because of an official title or elected position, but because their community has, over time, recognized and validated their wisdom, impartiality, and, most importantly, their eloquence. Their leadership is earned and demonstrated, not designated.

The application of this perspective is clearly visible in the *Gabaati*. The council of elders from the groom's family forms a task-oriented group with a clear objective: to secure a marriage agreement in a manner that honors both families and strengthens clan ties. Within this group, one or two elders may naturally emerge as the primary speakers or chief negotiators, not through a formal vote, but because they possess the most persuasive rhetorical skills and the deepest knowledge of proverbs and poetry. Their

communication is highly functional, aimed at guiding the group through a complex process of deliberation, negotiation, and consensus-building. They introduce the proposal, artfully listen to the other side's position, manage potential disagreements with diplomatic and face-saving language, and ultimately synthesize a final agreement that all parties can accept. Their role is to facilitate communication, ensuring every viewpoint is heard while keeping the group focused on its collective goal. The success of the negotiation—and by extension, the entire wedding process—is therefore a direct result of the effective emergent leadership demonstrated within this crucial small group.

Perspective 2: The Importance of High-Context Nonverbal Communication

Communication is far more than the explicit meaning of words. In many cultures, the nonverbal and contextual cues surrounding a message are as important, if not more so, than the message itself. This is the foundation of Edward T. Hall's '**High-Context Communication**' theory, which is particularly relevant in collectivist, high-context societies like Somalia where maintaining group harmony and avoiding direct confrontation are paramount (Hall, 1976). In a high-context culture, communication is often indirect, and meaning is derived from shared understandings, established relationships, and subtle nonverbal signals.

One can see this point aptly at work in all the small group exchanges throughout the Somali wedding. A lot of nonverbal and contextual communication takes place, for example, during the discussions among the elders. An extended period of silence may mean that the elders have been giving the matter considerable thought or that there is some subtle disagreement, contesting a point without having to verbally rebut the point under consideration. A slight, open-mouthed nod may indicate that one group of elders

has agreed on a response even before the group representative has uttered their first word. Eye contact is painstakingly managed to signify respect or deference. The use of poetic and allusive language, mentioned in the findings, is in of itself, a high-context method of communicating sensitive topics, such as, the amount of the dowry, primarily to save the face of the family when an amount is suggested non-directly. In a similar way, when the women's groups were organizing the Aroos feast, the ability to communicate efficiently was so high it was almost effortless, since the context of the gathering was richly shared. A simple shrug of a shoulder, an upturned eyebrow, or an eye glance between women could relay complex directions for food preparation or decoration, while all the women operated from a deep well of shared cultural and practical experiential knowledge. Like the elder group, relying on high-context and nonverbal communication creates social bonds among the women while allowing for efficient, smooth collaborative work that proves efficient communication is not always about the words we say, it is often about what we come to understand.

Perspective 3: Structuration Theory - Reproducing Culture Through Communication

Anthony Giddens' Structuration Theory provides a robust framework for how individual actions create and re-create social systems. Structuration Theory embraces a duality of structure: social structures (rules, traditions, institutions) enable and constrain human action while human actions (agency) create and recreate those very structures. The small group communication in the Aroos demonstrates this theory in action. The wedding tradition provides the 'structure'—the rules, roles, and expectations regarding how the

negotiation and celebrations should proceed. The elders, families, and other guests represent 'agents' engaged in communication that is shaped by this structure.

However, their actions are not fully determined. In each negotiation, the specific amount of the *meher*, the precise poetic phrases used, and the solutions to logistical problems are all new acts of the agency. When these acts successfully lead to a wedding, they reinforce and legitimize the traditional structure for the next generation. For example, by following the traditional format of the *Gabaati*, the elders' small group communication actively reproduces the cultural importance of clan alliances and the authority of elders. Yet, there is also room for subtle change. A group might agree to incorporate a new, modern element into the celebration or negotiate terms in a way that reflects contemporary economic realities. These small acts of agency can, over time, subtly modify the structure itself. Thus, the small group communication in the *Aroos* is the engine of both cultural continuity and gradual adaptation.

Perspective 4: Symbolic Convergence Theory - Creating a Shared Identity

Ernest Bormann's **Symbolic Convergence Theory (SCT)** explains how small groups develop a shared identity and consciousness. SCT posits that groups create and share stories, or "fantasy themes," which chain out among members and build a common understanding and emotional bond. Over time, these shared narratives converge to create a "symbolic convergence," a unified reality for the group. This theory is highly applicable to the function of communication in the *Aroos*.

The entire wedding process can be seen as an exercise in creating symbolic convergence between two previously separate kinship groups. The communication is rich with fantasy themes. During the *Gabaati*, elders from both sides tell stories that highlight the honour, generosity, and strong lineage of their respective clans. These are not just boasts; they are shared narratives designed to build mutual respect. During the celebration, the performance of *buraanbur* is a direct act of sharing fantasy themes—the poems recount heroic family histories and create a praiseworthy narrative for the new couple. The shared food, music, and dance are all symbolic acts that break down barriers and draw the two groups into a single, shared emotional experience. Through these communicative acts—the sharing of proverbs, the telling of histories, the singing of poems—the various small groups involved in the *Aroos* do not just plan an event. They actively construct a new, shared reality and a collective identity for the newly unified family, ensuring its cohesion and future success.

6. Conclusion and Suggestions

6.1. Synthesis of Findings and Final Conclusion

For the Academic Community:

1. **Pursue Primary Ethnographic Research:** This report, based on secondary data, highlights the richness of the *Aroos* as a site for communication research. A crucial next step is for researchers to conduct primary ethnographic studies involving participant-observation and in-depth interviews with elders, newlyweds, and male and female organizers. Such research could provide a more nuanced,

contemporary, and lived understanding of how these communication practices are enacted and adapted in real-time.

2. **Expand Theoretical Applications:** Future studies could employ more specific theories to deepen the analysis. For instance, research could focus on intercultural communication challenges in diaspora weddings where partners are from different clans or even different cultural backgrounds. Theories of conflict resolution could be applied to analyze how elders manage disagreements that threaten to derail negotiations. Further research into gender communication styles within the men's and women's groups would also yield valuable insights. Such research would not only enrich the field of communication studies but would also provide valuable insights for the Somali community as they continue to navigate the preservation of their unique and vibrant cultural heritage.

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